COMMUNITY ENGAGEMENT REPORT

EDUCATION SYSTEM OF PAKISTAN: CHALLENGES, INCLUSIVITY AND REFORMS

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Executive Summary

This report provides an in-depth analysis of Pakistan's education system, combining primary data from surveys and interviews with secondary research from reputable sources. Key findings highlight systemic issues such as inadequate infrastructure, gender disparities, outdated curricula, and insufficient teacher training. The report concludes with actionable recommendations to address these challenges, emphasizing policy reforms, community engagement, and Islamic principles of equity and knowledge.

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Introduction

Education is not merely the process of acquiring information — it is the foundation of a just, prosperous, and progressive society. In Islam and in global civil society, education is viewed as a right and a responsibility, meant to uplift individuals and communities alike. The purpose of education is to foster critical thinking, creativity, ethics, and social awareness — not just to prepare for exams but to prepare for life.

An educated society is one that builds hospitals, not just weapons; raises thinkers, not just followers; and empowers every citizen to contribute meaningfully to national development. The Holy Qur'an commands believers to seek knowledge, and the Prophet Muhammad (PBUH) declared that knowledge is obligatory for every Muslim — male or female.

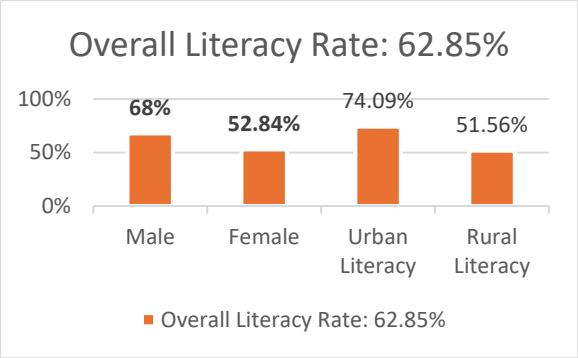
Current Problems in Pakistan's Education System

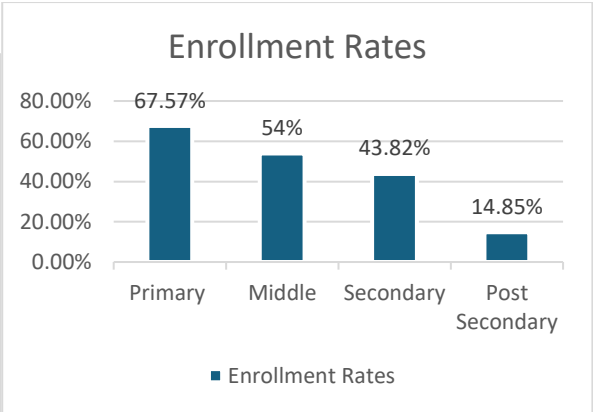
Despite constitutional guarantees such as **Article 25-A**, which promises free and compulsory education for children aged 5–16, Pakistan's education system suffers from decades of neglect. Major issues include:

- **Poor infrastructure** in both rural and urban schools
- **Underpaid and untrained teachers**
- **Inconsistent education policies** that change with governments
- **Outdated curriculum** focused on rote learning instead of skills
- **Lack of inclusive education** for special needs students
- **Gender inequality**, especially in rural and tribal areas
- **Corruption and ghost schools** that exist only on paper

These issues are not just administrative — they directly affect children's futures and the country's development.

According to **ASER Pakistan (2023)** and the **Pakistan Education Statistics**:





These numbers show a steep **drop in enrollment after primary school** — a clear sign of systemic failure. The rural–urban and male–female gaps remain alarmingly wide.

The Importance of Educational Equity

Educational equity means ensuring **fair access and opportunities** for every student — regardless of gender, economic status, location, or ability. In Pakistan, children from poor families often cannot afford basic education. Girls in conservative areas are forced to stay home. Students in villages may walk miles to attend school — only to sit on broken chairs without textbooks.

Equity also means listening to students' needs, respecting teachers, training them properly, and building schools that are **safe, inclusive, and modern**.

Why Special Education Matters

One of the most **ignored areas in Pakistan's education system** is **special education** — for students who are blind, deaf, autistic, physically challenged, or neurodivergent. These students deserve equal rights to learn, grow, and contribute to society.

Yet, in many areas, there are no ramps for wheelchairs, no visual/audio aids, no trained teachers, and **no dignity** in how these students are treated. Ignoring them is not only unethical — it is a **national loss of talent, creativity, and potential**.

This report gives **special attention to students with special needs** and includes field interviews with educators and administrators from this sector.

Closing of Introduction

This report is not just about collecting data — it is about **raising awareness**, **identifying problems**, and most importantly, **offering solutions**. It combines:

- **Real voices** from the ground
- **Survey and interview data**
- **National statistics**
- **Islamic teachings**
- And above all — a call to action.

Pakistan is a country full of talented youth. With the right education system — fair, inclusive, and strong — they can lead the world. Without it, they remain in chains.

Methodology

- **Types of participants** (students, general teachers, special educators, HOD's, principals)
- **Procedure** (Google Forms, face-to-face interviews, video recordings)
- **Tools used** (Forms, direct interviews, secondary research)

Survey & Interview Analysis

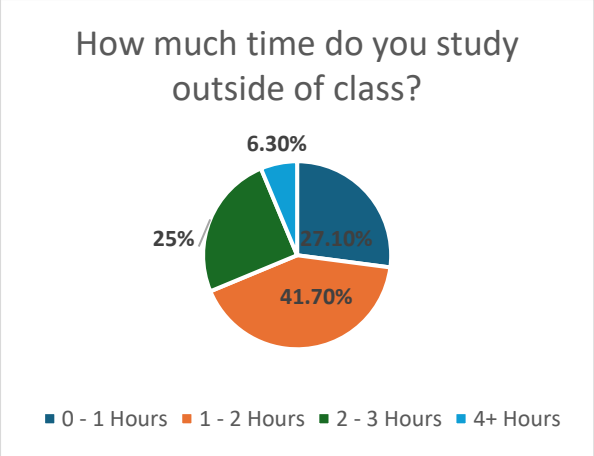
This section presents a multi-dimensional analysis of the education system in Pakistan based on both **primary data** (collected from students, teachers, and administrators) and **secondary research** (reliable national reports).

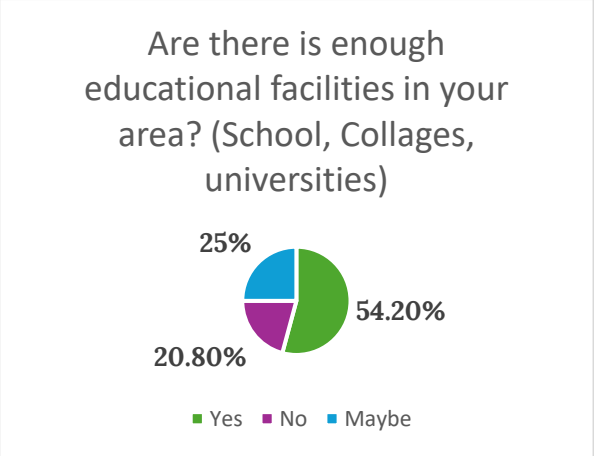
The study utilized a mixed-method approach:

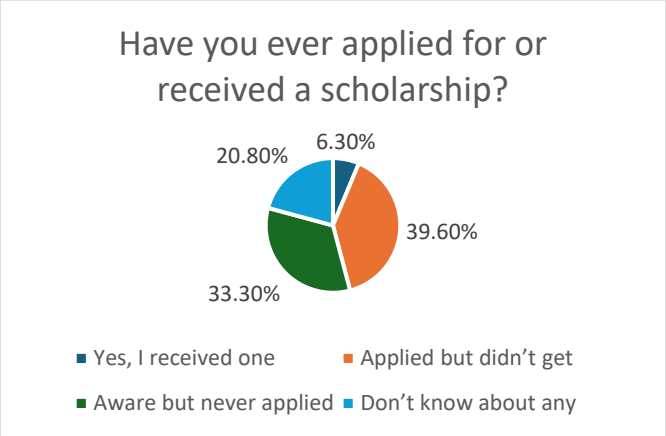
- **Quantitative data**: From Google Form surveys (students and teachers)
- **Qualitative data**: From face-to-face and video-recorded interviews with senior principals, HODs, and special educators

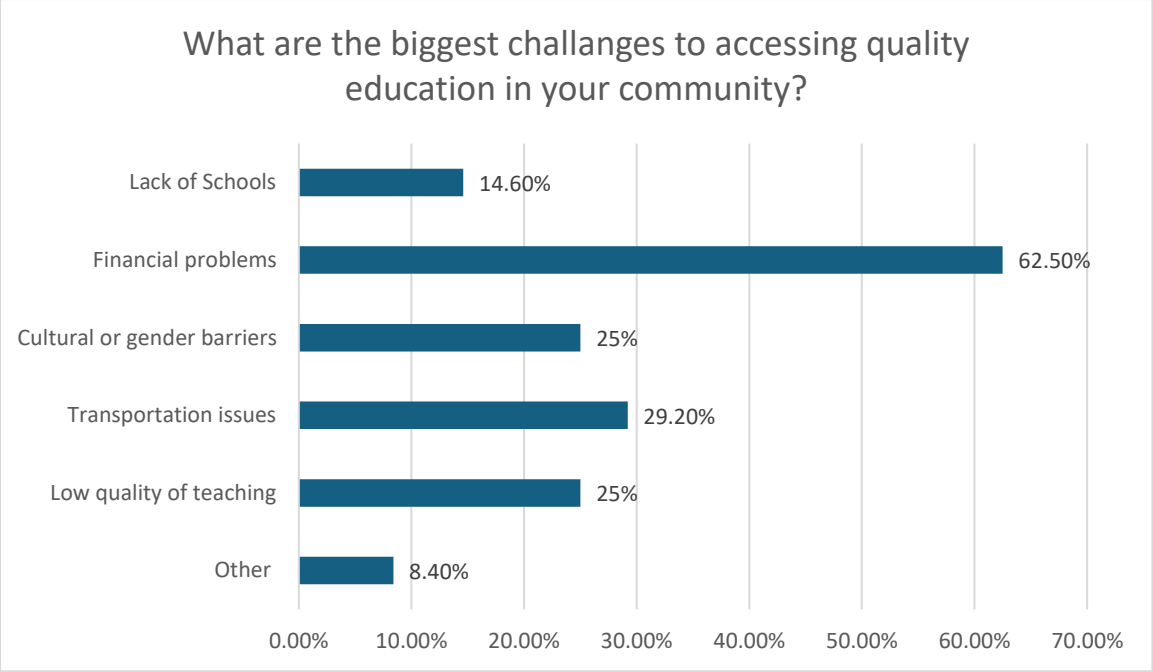
Student Perspectives

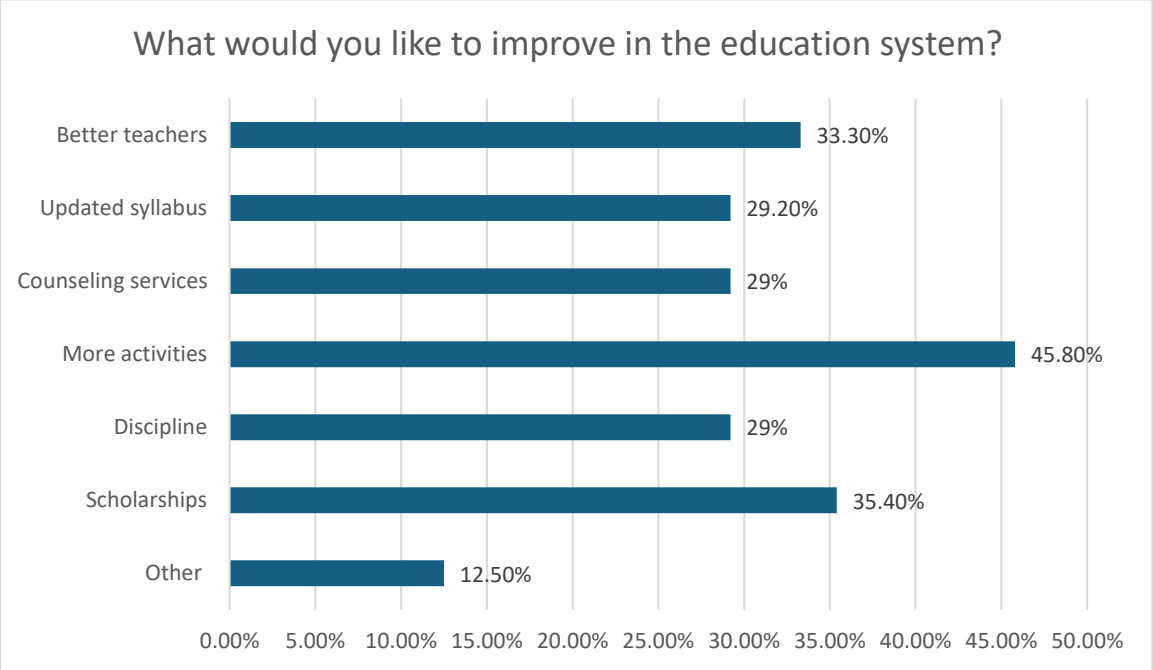
Students were asked about learning styles, academic stress, digital access, school environment, and social pressures. Most responses came from college and university-level students, many of whom have experienced both public and private schooling.


How much time do you study outside of class?
6.30%
25%
27.10%
41.70%
0 - 1 Hours
1 - 2 Hours
2 - 3 Hours
4+ Hours


Are there is enough educational facilities in your area? (School, Collages, universities)
25%
54.20%
20.80%
Yes
No
Maybe


Have you ever applied for or received a scholarship?
20.80%
6.30%
39.60%
33.30%
Yes, I received one
Applied but didn't get
Aware but never applied
Don't know about any





A concerning **60% of students reported studying less than 2 hours a day** outside of class. This low engagement with self-learning can be attributed to multiple factors — including poor time management, domestic responsibilities, lack of academic counseling, and the absence of quiet, resourceful environments conducive to study. Although **86% of students have access to smartphones or internet-enabled devices**, a large proportion of them admitted to using these more for **social media** and entertainment than for education. While the digital divide may appear to be shrinking in terms of access, the **digital usage gap** remains unaddressed — as most students are not trained to use these tools for learning purposes.

Approximately **45% of students expressed preference for blended learning models** (a combination of online and in-person classes), suggesting a shift in student mindset post-COVID-19. While many still value traditional face-to-face interaction with instructors, the convenience and flexibility of online content is seen as beneficial — especially for those who travel long distances or face health issues.

Financial pressure emerged as a recurring theme. A majority of respondents stated they could **not afford private coaching classes**, which have become almost necessary due to the low teaching quality in many institutions.

Interestingly, while **64% of students were aware of government or NGO-sponsored scholarships**, **81% had never applied**. The reasons included lack of guidance, perceived difficulty of the application process, and unavailability of support staff to help with form filling. This represents a critical gap between policy and practice — opportunities are present, but underutilized.

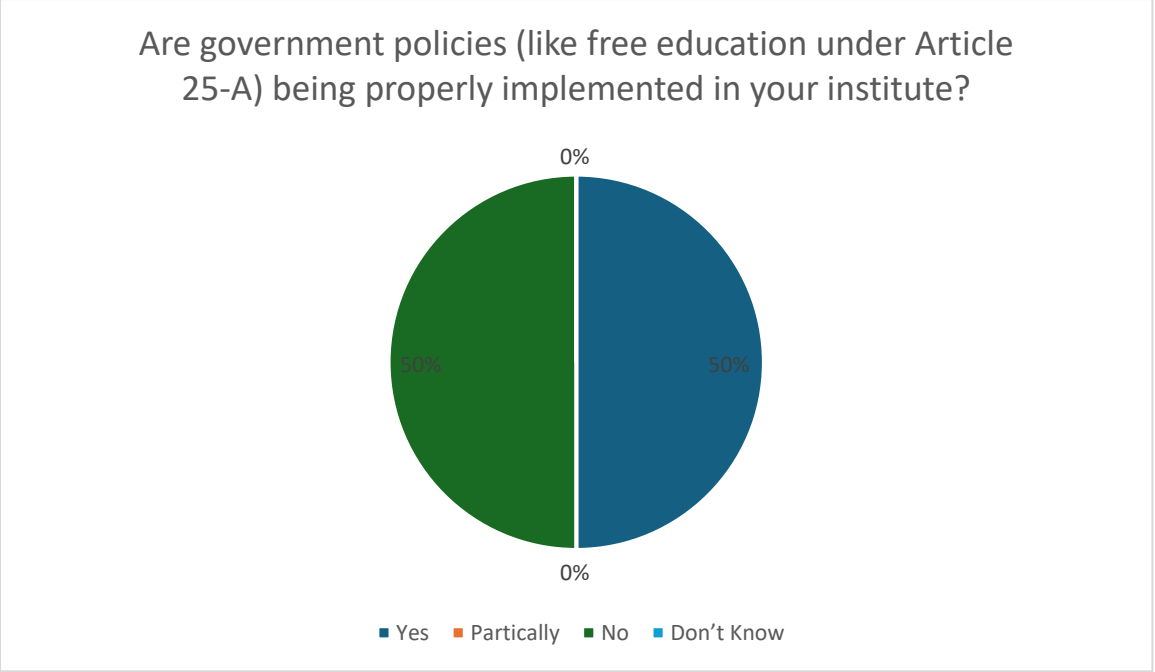
A significant **40% of students travel more than 5 kilometers each day** to attend classes, often by foot or unreliable public transport. The fatigue from this commute negatively affects attendance, punctuality, and academic engagement.

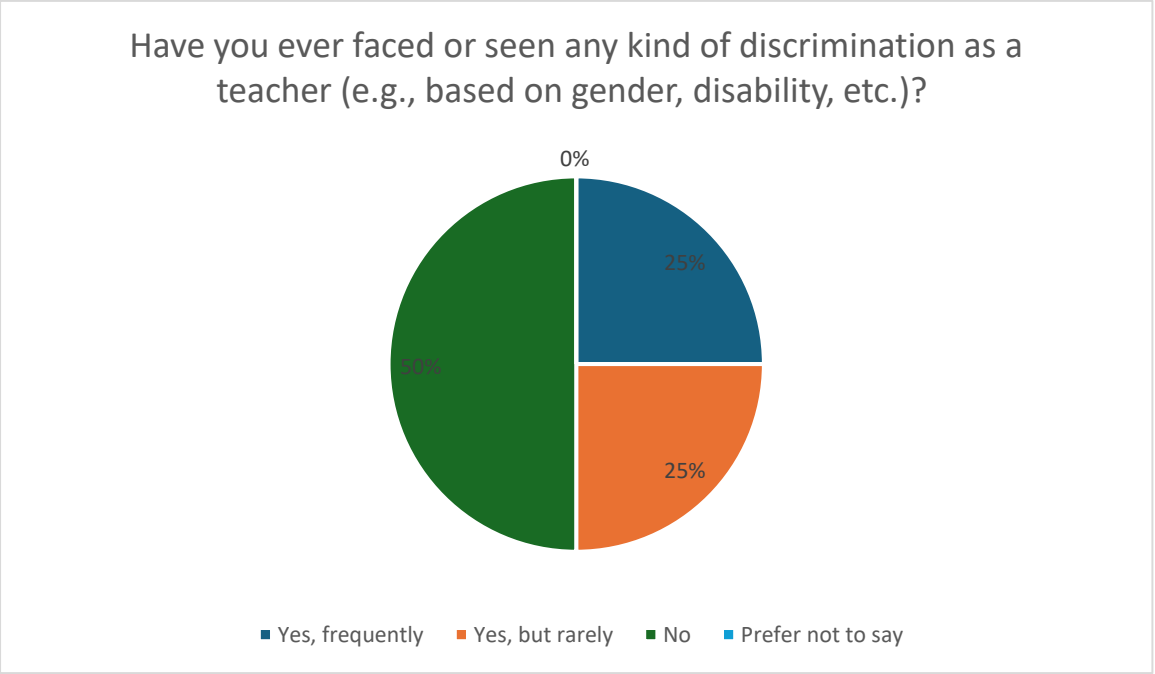
Meanwhile, **30% of respondents reported experiencing bullying or discrimination** — either from peers or even occasionally from staff. Students with disabilities, minority backgrounds, or different physical appearances were more likely to report feeling marginalized. This highlights the urgent need for **anti-bullying programs**, **counseling services**, and inclusive classroom training for teachers.

The voices of students reflect both resilience and frustration. They show ambition but face **structural barriers** that limit their potential. From broken chairs to broken policies, the system needs urgent, student-focused reforms. This report amplifies their voices to ensure they are not just heard — but acted upon.

Teacher Experiences

Interviews with teachers — both from general and special education — revealed the **systemic challenges educators face** in delivering quality education. They came from varying districts and included both male and female faculty members with diverse years of experience (ranging from 5 to 22 years).





All general education teachers reported **managing overcrowded classrooms** with **more than 50 students** at a time. Such environments restrict meaningful interaction, limit the ability to assess students individually, and reduce lesson quality. Teachers stated that they often play the role of not just educators, but also **counselors, administrators, and discipline officers** — without proper training for any of these roles.

None of the teachers had received **modern training on digital tools**, inclusive teaching, or updated pedagogical techniques in the past 2–3 years. Many described themselves as "**self-taught**" when it came to integrating videos, slides, or internet-based learning into their lessons.

This lack of training is not a reflection of unwillingness — but rather a **failure of the system to empower teachers**. They expressed willingness to attend workshops, webinars, and seminars but stated that such opportunities are either not offered or not communicated effectively.

When asked about **government policies** such as **Article 25-A**, teachers said they had a basic understanding of it. The others were either unaware or unclear about how these policies translate into daily school practice.

This demonstrates a critical need for **policy literacy among educators**, who are supposed to be the bridge between law and learners. Teachers often feel disconnected from top-down policies that rarely consider on-ground realities.

Special Education Teacher's View

The special educator reported being the **only trained special education teacher in their institute**. There were no ramps, no Braille books, and no therapy services. Despite teaching children with physical and cognitive disabilities, she received only **one training workshop in five years**.

She emphasized that most mainstream schools **refuse to admit special needs students**, and even when they do, they lack the resources to help them succeed.

Teachers are the **heart of the education system** — yet they are often overlooked in reform efforts. This study shows that teachers need not only better pay — but **professional respect, training, and support systems**. Investing in teachers means investing in every future student they will teach.

Key Findings

- **Out-of-School Children:** Over 22.8 million children are currently out of school in Pakistan (ASER, 2023), making it the second highest globally.
- **Drop in Enrollment:** Enrollment falls drastically from 67.57% at the primary level to only 14.85% at post-secondary level, indicating a major drop-out crisis.
- **Geographic Inequality:** Students in rural areas face long distances, fewer institutions, and poor transportation access — 40% of surveyed students walk more than 5 km to school or college.
- **Inadequate Facilities:** Around 70% of students reported lacking basic facilities such as functioning labs, clean water, desks, and electricity in their institutions.
- **Overcrowded Classrooms:** Teachers reported managing 50–60 students per class, reducing personal interaction and lesson effectiveness.
- **Lack of Teaching Resources:** Both teachers and students noted absence of multimedia tools, books, and internet connectivity in many institutions.
- **Digital Misuse:** While 86% of students have access to smartphones, most use them for entertainment rather than educational purposes.

- **Bullying and Harassment:** 30% of students reported experiencing bullying or discrimination in school, including gender-based, appearance-based, and ability-based abuse.
- **Awareness of Scholarships:** While 64% of students are aware of scholarships, 81% had never applied, suggesting a lack of guidance, support, and access to application help.
- **Economic Pressure:** Many students from lower-income households work part-time or skip meals to afford education, leading to poor academic performance and mental health challenges.

Islamic Perspective on Education

Islam places **great emphasis on the pursuit of knowledge**, making it a fundamental part of faith, worship, and societal development. Education is not seen as a luxury or privilege — rather, it is a **divine obligation and a means of personal and collective upliftment**.

This emphasis is not limited to a specific gender, social class, or ability level. Islam promotes **educational equity**, where men and women, the rich and the poor, and even those with physical or mental disabilities have the right — and duty — to seek knowledge.

Surah Al-Alaq (96:1–5):

"Read in the name of your Lord who created – created man from a clinging substance. Read, and your Lord is the Most Generous – Who taught by the pen – taught man that which he knew not."

These were the **very first verses revealed to the Prophet Muhammad (PBUH)**. It is deeply symbolic that the **first command from Allah was not to pray, fast, or give charity — but to read.** This alone establishes how central knowledge is in Islam.

Surah Az-Zumar (39:9):

"Are those who know equal to those who do not know?"

This rhetorical question from the Qur'an highlights that **knowledge elevates the status of individuals**, regardless of their social or economic background. Islam does not differentiate people by wealth, ethnicity, or physical ability — but values them based on their pursuit of knowledge and righteousness.

Hadith (Sunan Ibn Majah):

"Seeking knowledge is obligatory upon every Muslim."

This hadith affirms that **education is a duty** for all Muslims — **men and women, young and old**, able-bodied or differently-abled. It removes any excuse or barrier to learning and strongly encourages the creation of a society where education is accessible to all.

These divine and prophetic teachings strongly support the **core values of this project**:

- Making education **accessible to all**, especially girls and students with disabilities
- Encouraging **respectful, inclusive, and ethical learning environments**
- Promoting the dignity and potential of every learner — **regardless of ability or background**

In this light, improving Pakistan's education system is not only a **social and economic duty**, but also a **religious and moral obligation**.

Recommendations

Based on the research findings and expert insights, the following **recommendations** are proposed to address Pakistan's education challenges. These suggestions aim to promote **inclusive, equitable, and high-quality education** accessible to all — especially girls, students from low-income backgrounds, and students with disabilities.

1. **Increase budget allocation to at least 4% of GDP** in line with UNESCO standards.
2. **Renovate and maintain school buildings**, focusing on rural areas and government institutions.
3. Provide **basic facilities**: clean water, furniture, sanitation, electricity, and secure classrooms.
4. Install **disability-friendly infrastructure** (ramps, wide doors, visual aids, and therapy rooms).
5. Conduct **mandatory annual teacher training** on:
    - Child psychology
    - Inclusive education
    - Use of digital tools
    - Classroom management
6. Offer **career incentives and mental health support** for teachers to reduce burnout.
7. Provide **special needs teacher training** in every province with proper certification.
8. Revise the national curriculum to focus on:
    - Critical thinking
    - Skill-building
    - Ethics and civic responsibility
9. Replace rote exams with **activity-based assessments**, group work, and open-ended questioning.
10. Arrange regular **parent–teacher meetings**, especially in rural areas.
11. Launch awareness campaigns on:
    - Importance of girls' education
    - Access to scholarships
    - Role of parents in career guidance
12. Implement **anti-bullying policies** in all schools.

13. Establish **anonymous reporting channels** and appoint trained school counselors.

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